‘Yes, Sir,’ I said and walked towards the wall. I ran my index finger along the surface, tracing my flight path.

‘Do you know you were flying over enemy bunkers?’ the COO asked.

‘Yes, Sir.’

‘Do you know that a volley of missiles was fired towards your helicopter?’

‘No, Sir,’ I said, surprised at what he had just told me.

‘You barely escaped,’ he said. ‘The missiles went off a few metres below your helicopter. The ground formation passed this intelligence report to me.’

I did not know what to say, so I kept quiet.

‘What if one of them had hit you?’ he asked.

‘I was doing my duty, Sir.’ It was all I could say.

‘How many recce sorties have you flown till now?’ he asked.

‘I do not remember exactly, Sir,’ I answered. ‘But I think . . . around forty.’

‘All recce sorties by the air force contribute towards disclosing enemy disposition,’ he continued. ‘So you’re adding to better planning and strategies by our own forces by discharging your duties fearlessly and sincerely. I am proud of young officers like you. I wish you godspeed and good luck.’

This encounter with the COO left me thinking about life and death. It was the second time I had felt fear. I do not feel ashamed to admit it. But I made sure not to let it get to me. Hundreds of bullets would have been fired at my helicopter during all my sorties, hundreds of missiles would have targeted me, but I did not think about it at all. A fully loaded INSAS assault rifle and a revolver in my helicopter would often remind me that I might be taken as a prisoner of war if my helicopter crashed behind enemy lines. But I continued to do what I was supposed to. The chaos of war doesn’t allow you to overthink, only act. There is no place for thoughts, only orders. And I was busy following orders. It was all I had learnt to do. It is all that is taught to any soldier.